

Assessment 4-Aug notes

1. Narrow the flagship before adding more content

For the first field phase, use a narrower formulation:

Recommended first research question

What prevents rural household businesses from converting recurring income into emergency resilience and productive assets, and which small interventions could realistically improve that progression?

Recommended first population

Choose one:

1. Women-led household businesses;

The most practical first cohort is likely:

15–20 women-led household businesses or cooperative members in one current commune in Bình Định.

Bình Định is credible because it is connected to your personal history and gives you a genuine route into the field. Do not claim to study “rural Vietnam” based on one location. Call it:

An exploratory case study in one Bình Định community.

2. What to build on the website now

The flagship page should become a **research operating record**, not a marketing page.

A visitor should be able to answer six questions within two minutes:

- 1. What exactly is being studied?
- 2. Why are you personally doing it?
- 3. Who has been consulted?
- 4. How was the evidence collected?
- 5. What changed because of the evidence?
- 6. What is being tested next?

Recommended website architecture

A. Project overview

Place this at the top of the flagship page.

Suggested copy:

From Income to Assets is an independent public-interest research and learning project initiated in January 2025. It examines how rural household businesses and micro-entrepreneurs move from income generation toward emergency resilience, responsible use of credit, productive investment, and asset formation.

The project combines desk research, structured field conversations, policy analysis, and small-scale tool testing. Its first field phase focuses on one defined community in Bình Định.

The project is exploratory. It does not claim that its current participants represent all rural households in Vietnam, nor does it claim causal impact before a pilot has been evaluated.

Immediately below, show a status box:

Field	Public status
Project initiated	January 2025
Current phase	Exploratory field research
Geography	One defined community in Bình Định
Structured interviews	[verified number]
Exploratory conversations	[verified number]
Practitioner interviews	[verified number]

Published research artifacts	[number]
Current intervention	Tool co-design / pilot preparation
Last updated	[date]

Do not use a number until you can reconstruct and verify it.

B. Methods and research ethics page

This is one of the highest-value additions because it turns informal interest into credible research practice.

Include:

- research question;
- target population;
- recruitment method;
- interview format;
- distinction between structured interviews and informal conversations;
- interview dates and geography;
- anonymization approach;
- consent process;
- data-storage practice;
- limitations;
- conflicts and independence statement.

Suggested language:

Participants are recruited through personal introductions, community organizations, and participant referrals. The sample is purposive rather than statistically representative. Findings are therefore used to identify mechanisms and hypotheses, not to estimate prevalence across Vietnam.

No bank account numbers, identification documents, passwords, or personally identifiable financial records are collected. Participants may decline any question. Quotations are anonymized unless explicit permission for attribution has been provided.

Also state:

This project is independently initiated by Thu Ho. It does not represent Grab, Fulbright University Vietnam, or Sa. Partners. Collaborative or commercially produced Sa. Partners work is identified separately, with authorship and roles disclosed.

C. Retrospective fieldwork ledger

Because you have been speaking with people since January 2025, reconstruct the work honestly rather than retroactively treating every conversation as a formal interview.

Use three categories:

Category	Definition
Structured interview	Conducted using a prepared guide, with a date, participant category, notes, and consent status
Exploratory conversation	Relevant discussion without a formal protocol
Retrospective recollection	Past discussion reconstructed later from memory, messages, calendar records, or notes

Recommended private ledger:

ID	Date	Location	Participant category	Format	Evidence available	Consent status	Main insight	Follow-up
TN-H H-01	202 5-03 -12	Bình Định	Household business	Exploratory	Zalo timestamp + notes	Private use	Seasonal income disrupts saving	Formal follow-up
TN-C OOP- 02	202 5-08 -20	Bình Định	Cooperative member	Structured	Interview notes	Anonymous quotation	Credit size mismatched to cycle	Validate with lender

On the public website, publish only aggregated counts and anonymized findings.

This ledger is much more convincing than saying you “collected samples for 18 months.”

D. Evidence ledger

Your research currently contains precise claims about account use, rural access, institutional ownership, national plans, and financial-inclusion outcomes. Some of these need direct source verification before they remain public.

Create a downloadable evidence table:

Claim	Source	Source type	Year	Confidence	Competing evidence	Use in project
Account ownership has expanded faster than active usage	World Bank / SBV	Primary institutional data	Latest available	High	Definitions differ by source	Problem brief
Rural households prefer informal credit because it is faster	Interviews + literature	Mixed	2025–26	Medium	Cost and coercion risks vary	Field note
Financial literacy alone changes saving behavior	Academic studies	Research literature	Multiple	Contested	Effects may be small without product redesign	Pilot design

Use confidence labels:

- **High confidence:** multiple primary sources or replicated findings;
- **Moderate confidence:** one reliable source plus supporting evidence;
- **Exploratory:** field observation or small-sample finding;
- **Contested:** credible evidence exists on both sides.

The State Bank of Vietnam’s own framing of the National Financial Inclusion Strategy includes financial education, consumer protection, product diversification, infrastructure, and coordination across levels. That gives you a legitimate policy base, but your analysis should test implementation rather than imply that these issues are absent from official strategy. ([SBV](#))

E. Field-listening note

Title it:

What I Heard—and What Changed My Mind

This should not merely summarize comments. Use a hypothesis-revision structure.

Before listening	What participants said or did	Revised interpretation
Lack of saving is primarily a financial-literacy problem	Participants understood saving but experienced volatile cash flow and recurring family shocks	Income volatility and product design may matter more than awareness
Formal credit is avoided because of low trust	Some trusted banks but could not meet documentation, timing, or repayment requirements	Administrative fit may be as important as institutional trust
Digital access lowers transaction friction	Participants sometimes required assistance from relatives or agents	Trusted human intermediation remains part of digital access
Productive loans lead to asset creation	Some borrowing substituted for emergency consumption	Credit purpose can change after shocks; resilience must precede leverage

End with:

- what the evidence currently suggests;
- what it does not establish;
- which assumption you abandoned;
- what you need to test next.

This is one of the strongest possible scholarship artifacts because it demonstrates intellectual humility.

F. Policy options matrix

Do not jump immediately to one national recommendation. Compare three pathways.

Option	Mechanism	Delivery channel	Beneficiary	Main risk	Evaluation indicator
Financial-capability tool only	Better household planning and debt comparison	Cooperative or Women's Union	Household businesses	Knowledge may not change behavior	Recordkeeping and decision comprehension
Tool plus trusted intermediary	Repeated support through local group leaders	Savings-credit group or cooperative	Low-confidence users	Delivery cost and inconsistency	Completion and follow-up behavior
Tool plus suitable financial product	Capability support paired with savings or credit design	Licensed financial institution	Eligible micro-enterprises	Mis-selling or over-borrowing	Savings activity, repayment quality, productive use

For each option, state:

- lead institution;
- required partner;
- cost driver;
- legal or operational constraint;
- failure condition;
- scale condition.

G. Public-finance model

Build a simple spreadsheet and a one-page explanation.

Do not estimate costs from imagination. Obtain actual quotations or partner estimates for:

- travel;
- venue;
- participant transport;
- printed materials;
- facilitator hours;
- partner staff time;
- communication;
- follow-up;

- data collection;
- contingency;
- evaluation.

Show:

Cost block	Fixed or variable	Source
Tool design	Fixed	Recorded hours or market quote
Session facilitation	Fixed	Facilitator quote
Participant materials	Per participant	Printing quote
Transport support	Per participant	Local estimate
Field travel	Per visit	Actual transport cost
Follow-up calls	Per participant	Communication estimate
Evaluation	Fixed	Researcher time
Administration	Percentage	Explicit assumption

Then present low, base, and high scenarios.

The goal is not to show a cheap pilot. It is to show that you understand:

A policy intervention has delivery and administrative costs, not only program-content costs.

H. Version history and learning log

Every major artifact should show:

- version;
- publication date;
- revision date;
- reason for revision;
- evidence that triggered the change.

Example:

Version	Change	Reason
v0.1	Initial rural wealth ladder	Desk research
v0.2	Added resilience stage before productive credit	Household interviews showed shocks were absorbing business loans
v0.3	Added trusted-intermediary channel	Participants reported assisted digital use
v0.4	Revised pilot metrics	Practitioner feedback challenged self-reported confidence as a sufficient outcome

This proves that the project is alive rather than designed retrospectively for an application.

3. The most credible concrete pilot

Pilot: Rural Household Financial-Resilience Sprint

Target cohort

- 15–20 participants;
- one cooperative, Women's Union group, or household-business network;
- one current commune in Bình Định;
- participants with recurring but variable household or business income.

Intervention

Week 0 — Baseline

- income sources and seasonality;
- recent financial shock;
- current savings method;
- debt obligations;
- recordkeeping behavior;
- one productive asset goal.

Week 1 — Group learning session

Use four practical tools:

1. Weekly household and business cash-flow sheet;
2. Emergency-buffer target;
3. Productive-debt versus consumption-debt decision checklist;
4. Asset-goal and financing calendar.

Weeks 2–4 — Practice period

Participants use the tools. Conduct one short check-in through the trusted intermediary.

Week 5 — Follow-up

Measure:

- tool completion;
- ability to compare two credit options;
- recordkeeping frequency;
- whether an emergency-buffer action was initiated;
- whether a planned borrowing decision changed;
- participant usefulness rating;
- reasons for non-use.

What the pilot may claim

- usability;
- comprehension;
- short-term behavior;
- delivery feasibility;
- participant feedback.

What it may not claim

- increased household wealth;
- poverty reduction;
- better long-term credit outcomes;
- province-wide representativeness;
- causal impact without a proper comparison design.

The public output should be:

Pilot design → actual cost → participation → results → failures → revised design

A documented unsuccessful pilot is more credible than an untested perfect framework.

4. Whom to meet—and why

Use three evidence rings.

Ring 1: People experiencing the problem

Target **12–15 structured interviews**.

Participant group	What you need to learn
Household-business owners	Cash-flow volatility, recordkeeping, debt, savings, business investment
Smallholders	Seasonality, input finance, shock management, asset decisions
Informal workers	Income irregularity, formal-finance eligibility, digital behavior
Women managing household finances	Household-business trade-offs, healthcare and education shocks
Cooperative members	Collective purchasing, market access, credit and savings mechanisms

Do not ask only, “What problems do you face?” Ask for specific recent episodes:

- “Tell me about the last unexpected expense.”
- “What did you do first?”
- “Who did you borrow from?”
- “What alternatives did you reject?”
- “What happened to the original repayment plan?”

Behavioral episodes are more reliable than general opinions.

Ring 2: Local delivery actors

Target **6–8 interviews or observations**.

Vietnam Bank for Social Policies

Speak with:

- one commune transaction-point officer;
- one savings-and-credit group leader;
- one borrower-support or local coordination officer.

VBSP is particularly useful because it operates through commune-level transaction points and village-level savings and credit groups, giving you a real window into how policy credit reaches households. Its current national structure includes nearly 10,000 commune/ward transaction points and more than 165,000 savings and credit groups. ([VBSP](#))

Questions:

- Which eligible households do not borrow, and why?
- Which borrowers struggle after disbursement?
- How are productive and emergency uses distinguished?
- What administrative tasks create the most friction?
- Which outcomes are measured beyond repayment?

Bình Định Women's Union

Ask for:

- access to one women-led household-business group;
- review of your interview language;
- identification of common financial capability needs;
- feedback on whether your proposed tool is understandable.

The provincial Women's Union provides an existing local organizational route; approach it for learning and access, not endorsement. ([Hội Liên Hiệp Phụ Nữ Việt Nam](#))

Bình Định Cooperative Alliance

Speak with:

- one provincial support officer;
- two cooperative managers;
- members from one selected cooperative.

The current provincial cooperative network is large enough to provide diverse cases, with hundreds of cooperatives and tens of thousands of members under the reorganized provincial structure. ([VCA](#))

Questions:

- Do members separate household and enterprise cash flows?
- What prevents reinvestment?
- What kind of credit or insurance is missing?

- Which training has actually changed behavior?
- What data do cooperatives already collect?

Bình Định Farmers' Union

Ask for:

- introductions to ordinary members, not only model high-performing farmers;
- one field visit;
- examples of failed investments or unsuccessful borrowing;
- barriers to moving from production into higher-value markets.

The Union is currently emphasizing substantive support and organizational renewal for farmers, which creates a relevant institutional entry point. ([Hội Nông Dân](#))

Ring 3: Financial and policy system actors

Target **4–6 interviews**.

Actor	Why speak with them
Rural bank or Agribank branch officer	Product eligibility, documentation, collateral, repayment design
Licensed microfinance practitioner	Small-loan delivery, savings behavior, group mechanisms
Insurance or consumer-protection practitioner	Shock protection and mis-selling risk
State Bank or banking-strategy researcher	National financial-inclusion architecture and regulatory constraints
Public-finance or development economist	Evaluation design, welfare rationale, opportunity cost
Fintech or digital-product specialist	eKYC, assisted adoption, data and distribution constraints

TYM is a useful benchmark interview even if it is not your local operating partner. Its model combines credit, savings, training, community support, and field-based delivery rather than treating microcredit as a standalone product. ([Tymfund](#))

Do not approach these experts asking them to validate your conclusion. Ask:

“What part of my thesis is probably wrong?”

That question will produce much better evidence.

5. Minimum fieldwork package for a polished project

A credible first research cycle would contain:

Activity	Minimum standard
Structured household interviews	12–15
Exploratory conversations reconstructed from earlier work	Report separately
Local intermediary interviews	6–8
National or technical expert interviews	4–6
Direct observation sessions	2
Co-design workshop	1, with 8–12 participants
Tool test	15–20 participants
Follow-up period	30 days
Field-listening note	1
Policy options matrix	1
Costed pilot memo	1
Public revision note	1

This is enough to look deeply invested without pretending to have conducted a statistically representative national study.

6. Suggested household interview protocol

Keep each structured interview to 40–60 minutes.

Section 1 — Household and livelihood

1. What are the household's main sources of income?
2. Which months are strongest and weakest?
3. Who makes financial decisions in the household?

Section 2 — Recent financial behavior

4. Tell me about the most recent unexpected expense.
5. How was it financed?
6. What other options were considered?
7. Did the expense change a business or asset plan?

Section 3 — Saving and borrowing

8. Where is money kept between income and expenditure?
9. What makes saving difficult?
10. What was the last loan used for?
11. Did its actual use differ from the original plan?
12. What part of formal borrowing is hardest: eligibility, paperwork, timing, repayment, trust, or cost?

Section 4 — Productive assets

13. What asset would most improve household income?
14. Why has it not been acquired?
15. What would make the investment feel safe enough?

Section 5 — Tool testing

16. Would a cash-flow calendar or debt-comparison tool be useful?
17. Who would you trust to explain it?
18. Would you use a paper, Zalo, app, cooperative, bank, or group-based version?

End with:

“What have I failed to ask that matters more than my questions?”

7. Research-integrity rules

These rules will make the project more credible than polished visual design alone.

Count evidence honestly

Do not convert old casual conversations into “structured interviews.” Label them accurately.

Separate research from community impact

- A report is a research output.
- An interview is engagement.
- A tool test is a community activity.
- Adoption or behavior change is an outcome.

Do not collapse these categories.

Protect participants

- No names without explicit written consent;
- no ID numbers, bank details, balances, passwords, or account screenshots;
- no identifiable health or debt information on the public website;
- no individualized investment, loan, tax, or legal advice;
- no photographs presented as evidence without permission.

Publish limitations prominently

State:

- small purposive sample;
- one local geography;
- possible referral bias;
- self-reported financial behavior;
- limited follow-up period;
- no causal inference.

Separate your roles

For every artifact, label:

- personally authored;
 - co-authored;
 - independently researched;
 - Sa. Partners collaborative work;
 - professional insight generalized from work;
 - confidential employer evidence omitted.
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8. What to do in the next 30, 60, and 90 days

Days 1–14: Make the existing work auditable

1. Reconstruct the January 2025–present fieldwork ledger.
2. Separate structured interviews, exploratory conversations, and retrospective recollections.
3. Publish the project charter.
4. Publish methods, ethics, and limitations.
5. Audit every numerical claim in the flagship.
6. Build the evidence ledger.
7. Identify one Bình Định commune, cooperative, or Women’s Union group.
8. Send 10 institutional outreach requests.

Days 15–45: Produce original field evidence

1. Conduct 12–15 household interviews.
2. Interview 6–8 local delivery actors.
3. Complete two observation visits.
4. Publish the first field-listening note.
5. Produce a stakeholder map.
6. Revise the wealth-progression framework based on evidence.
7. Publish “What Changed My Mind — Version 1.”

Days 46–75: Co-design the intervention

1. Hold one workshop with participants and intermediaries.
2. Test language and usability of the checklist.

3. Obtain actual cost estimates.
4. Produce the policy-options matrix.
5. Produce the public-finance note.
6. Finalize the pilot protocol and safeguards.

Days 76–90+: Run and document the pilot

1. Run the 15–20-person financial-resilience sprint.
 2. Conduct a 30-day follow-up.
 3. Publish anonymized results.
 4. Document non-use and dropout.
 5. Publish actual cost per participant.
 6. State what you would redesign before scaling.
 7. Ask one partner for a factual verification letter—not a generic endorsement.
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9. Outreach message

Use a message like this in Vietnamese:

Chào Anh/Chị,

Tôi đang thực hiện một dự án nghiên cứu độc lập vì lợi ích cộng đồng về quá trình các hộ kinh doanh và hộ gia đình nông thôn chuyển từ tạo thu nhập sang hình thành dự phòng tài chính, sử dụng tín dụng có trách nhiệm và đầu tư vào tài sản phục vụ sinh kế. Giai đoạn đầu của nghiên cứu tập trung vào một cộng đồng cụ thể tại Bình Định.

Tôi mong được trao đổi với Anh/Chị khoảng 30–45 phút để hiểu rõ hơn về thực tế triển khai, những khó khăn của người dân và những hạn chế trong giả thuyết nghiên cứu hiện tại của tôi. Tôi không đại diện cho Grab, Fulbright hay bất kỳ cơ quan nhà nước nào; nghiên cứu được thực hiện độc lập. Nội dung trao đổi sẽ được ẩn danh trừ khi Anh/Chị đồng ý cho phép trích dẫn danh tính.

Mục tiêu của buổi trao đổi không phải để tìm sự xác nhận cho một giải pháp có sẵn, mà để kiểm tra điều gì trong cách hiểu hiện tại của tôi còn thiếu hoặc chưa đúng.

Ask initially for **learning access**, not “partnership,” sponsorship, or endorsement.

10. The proof hierarchy to target

Level	Artifact	What it demonstrates
1	Policy reports	Analytical interest
2	Evidence and methods ledger	Academic discipline
3	Structured interviews	Proximity to lived problems
4	Revised thesis	Intellectual honesty
5	Co-designed tool	Responsiveness to users
6	Costed pilot	Implementation capability
7	Actual tool use	Community usefulness
8	Follow-up behavior or institutional adoption	Early community effect

Your current portfolio is approximately at **Levels 1–3**, depending on how much of the historical interviewing can be documented. The strongest next move is not to publish more claims of national significance. It is to move visibly and honestly through Levels 4–7.

The finished flagship should communicate:

I did not create a website to demonstrate that I already knew the answer. I created a research process that exposes my assumptions, brings me closer to the people affected, and converts learning into a small intervention that can be evaluated.